

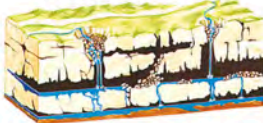
CAVES

Caves are hollows beneath the surface of the Earth. The biggest ones are all found in rock called limestone and some are huge. The world's biggest cave, in Sarawak, is so large that you could fit 800 tennis courts in it. Yet these caves began simply as cracks or holes in the rock that, over thousands of years, were made bigger by rainwater trickling into them and dissolving the surrounding rock.



Drip . . .

The rainwater that seeps into the ground is very slightly acidic and begins to dissolve the limestone.



Drip . . .

The rainwater continues to dissolve the rock. It widens the cracks into pits, passages and caves.



Drip

Over thousands of years, the passages and caves may join up to make a huge underground system.

Going down

Water dripping from the ceiling of a cave leaves behind a mineral called calcite. Very slowly, this grows downward in an icicle shape that is called a stalactite.

The stream disappears underground into a pothole.

This pothole, or tunnel, leads straight down through the rock. It was made by a stream wearing away the rock.

Limestone is a very common rock. It is made from the skeletons and shells of tiny sea creatures that died millions of years ago.

